

Notes of International Politics

University of Mannheim Department of Political Science

International Politics

Filippo Panfoli 2202955

✉ filippo.panfoli@students.uni-mannheim.de | 🐙 PanfoliF |

🆔 0009-0000-7861-8036 | 🌐 <https://github.com/PanfoliF>

Replication materials / L^AT_EX sources: 📁 PanfoliF/Appunti di International Politics

Version: v1.1 | **Last updated:** August 20, 2026

Keywords: game theory; deterrence; animal behaviour; formal models; bargaining

JEL: C72; D82

Prepared for: International Politics, taught by Prof. Dr. Bernard Beber

August 20, 2026

Session 2, February 16: Grand theories of war and peace

*** (Bueno de Mesquita, 2013)[Chapter 5]

- (Levy, n.d.)
- (Lake, 2011)
- (Lake et al., 2021)
- (Milner et al., 2023)
- (“One World, Rival Theories”, n.d.)

1 Bueno de Mesquita, 2013 Chapter 5

- War is generally inefficient compared to reaching a negotiated settlement.
- The risks of war may be exacerbated by uncertainty, making credible commitments, or winner-takes-all situation.
- Some important neorealist hypotheses about international peace and stability do not flow logically from that theory's core assumptions. Other important neorealist hypotheses are falsified by the empirical record.
- The link between power transition theory's assumptions and hypotheses is more clear-cut than is true in the case of neorealism.
- Some core power transition hypotheses follow from the theory's logic and are supported by evidence; others either do not follow logically or are not borne out by evidence.
- The power transition theory outperforms neorealism when it comes to offering a structural explanation for war, but its weaknesses point to a need to reconsider its approach to domestic politics.

Consider that estimates of war-related deaths per year in the past 100 years vary approximately from 1 to 2 million.

1.1 War and Uncertainty

The ex ante problems that seem to lead to war can be reduced to three main factors: (1) uncertainty, (2) commitment problems, and (3) indivisibility of issues (Fearon 1995; Slantchev 2003).

1 Absence of **credible commitments** between the sides.

1.1 The inability to **commit to negotiating** patiently rather than seizing the first-strike advantage exacerbates the risk of war (Powell 1999; Slantchev 2003)

1.2 The idea is that the Israelis give up some land in exchange for a guarantee of peace. An alternative formulation reverses the sequence of concessions—the Palestinian Authority disarms its factions that engage in violence against Israel in return for land concessions. Either approach is likely to fail because each induces a fundamental commitment problem.

Land for peace suffers from a time inconsistency problem.

2 Dispute is about an **indivisible objective** → No settlement can produce a compromise in this case of indivisibility, and so there is a severe risk of war. If control over all the land currently held by Israel is truly its irreducible objective, then the land is viewed as indivisible by Hamas.

3 This **uncertainty about the true probability of victory** or defeat might arise out of private (secret) information about the morale of their fighting forces, about knowledge of outside help, about the quality of their war plans, or a host of other possible factors.

1.2 Realist Theory

Neorealist theorists believe that the distribution of power in the international system is a major factor in determining whether international affairs are stable or unstable. Stability refers to circumstances in which the sovereignty of key states is preserved (Gulick 1955). Instability refers to changes in the composition of the international system, especially changes involving the disappearance or emergence of “key” states following large wars. Key states are those whose assistance might be necessary to counteract a threat from a rival coalition of states.

In addressing war and instability, neorealist theories start with the following four assumptions:

1. International politics is anarchic. $\Rightarrow$ there is no supranational authority that can enforce agreements between states.
2. States, as rational unitary entities, are the central actors in international politics. $\Rightarrow$ domestic politics does not influence international politics.
3. States seek to maximize their security above all else and consider other factors only after security is assured. $\Rightarrow$ states are not willing to trade away their security for other benefits. Other possible goals, such as wealth, are pursued only after security has been assured (Waltz 1979, 126).
4. States seek to increase their power as long as doing so does not place their security at risk. $\Rightarrow$ states accept being weaker than they might otherwise be if the pursuit of greater power would place their security at risk.

Most important neorealist conclusions

1. Bipolar systems are more stable than multipolar systems.
2. States engage in balancing behavior so that power becomes more or less equally divided among states over time.
3. States mimic, or echo, one another’s behavior.

2 How Well Does Neorealism Do in Explaining War and Instability?

2.1 Bipolarity and Stability

The argument that bipolar structures are more stable than multipolar ones is built on the claim that there is more uncertainty in a multipolar system than in a bipolar one.

Bipolarity is thought to alleviate two of the conditions we have discussed that are thought to increase the risk of war: uncertainty and commitment problems.

There are several problems with the argument that because bipolar systems encompass less uncertainty than multipolar systems they yield greater stability. This argument is not implied logically by the four key assumptions of neorealism.

1. First, variation in the response to uncertainty violates the unitary rational actor assumption, which contends that important choices in international politics are driven by structural factors, not by considerations internal to the state.

-
2. Second, if different decision makers respond to uncertainty in different ways, then there is no reason to expect any empirical relationship between bipolarity and stability at all.
 3. Third, if leaders differ in how they respond to uncertainty, then the third hypothesis (that states mimic one another) does not hold up.
 4. taking the neorealist assumptions into account, we can show that it is logically true that more distributions of power are stable in a multipolar world than in a bipolar world.

2.2 Bipolarity and Stability 2

Stability in a multipolar world is not limited to the situation of exact power equality. This is in marked contrast to the bipolar world, in which stability can be achieved only through a perfectly equal division of resources between the two blocs.

Thus, it appears that the first neorealist hypothesis, that bipolarity promotes stability and multipolarity promotes instability, is logically flawed given the assumptions of the theory.

Further, it seems that a true balance of power is essential for stability in a bipolar world, but not in a multipolar one, contradicting the second hypothesis. A vast array of power distributions can produce stability. In a multipolar environment, an exact balance of power is irrelevant.

Either the balance of power does not matter in multipolarity or the term is defined to mean any system in which each actor is essential. In the latter case, so many systems qualify as a balance-of-power system that the concept doesn't have much meaning in our search for answers.

2.3 History and Neorealist Empirical Claims

1. The international system was multipolar in structure from 1648 until the defeat of Germany in 1945. Thus, between 1648 and 1945 there were many major powers with no one or two predominating. $\Rightarrow$ The bipolar system began in 1945 and lasted until about 1989.
2. Using Jack Levy's (1983) classification of great powers since 1492, we can determine whether the longevity of the bipolar system was comparatively long or short. $\Rightarrow$
3. Another way to evaluate the stability of the international system is to examine the frequency of wars among the most influential states in the world
4. The UN Security Council (UNSC), then, by institutionalizing a multipolar decision-making structure, has provided a counterweight to bipolarity. This too may be an explanation for the long peace.
5. The average interval between general wars is thirty-four years; the longest interval is ninety-nine years, much longer than the so-called long peace. It appears, then, that the bipolar, long peace cannot be considered unusually long after all and that bipolarity is not a superior treatment for the disease of major power war than is multipolarity.

2.4 Historical Record of Essential and Inessential States

An essential state is any state that can join a losing coalition and, by dint of its membership and the power it can bring to bear, turn that coalition into a blocking coalition or a winning coalition.

Inessential states are states that are unable to turn even one losing alliance into a winning or blocking coalition.

-
1. Essential states never become inessential.
 2. Essential states are never eliminated from the international system.
 3. Inessential states never become essential states.
 4. Inessential states are always eliminated from the international system.

Each of these propositions is historically false.

2.5 Balance of Power and Neorealism

Perhaps the most common claim among neorealist theorists is that war occurs only when both sides believe that their chance of winning is greater than 50 percent. This is a partial statement of what has come to be known as the balance-of-power theory. It invokes the idea that war is the product of mutual optimism by rival states, meaning that they overestimate their chances of victory

If the neorealist hypothesis were correct, we should observe no wars initiated by the weaker side. The evidence fails to support the hypothesis.

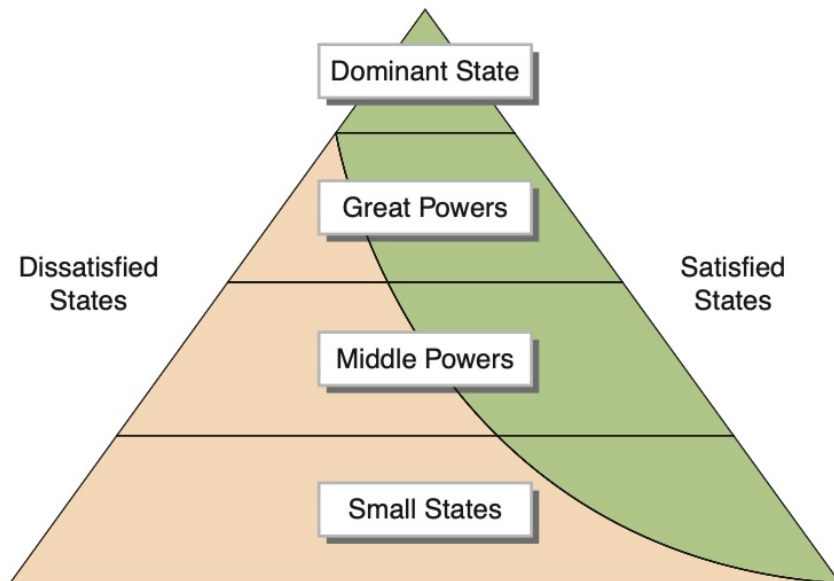
3 The Power Transition

Building on the work of Edward Carr (1939, 1945) and Organski (1958) constructed what was perhaps the first challenge to realism that was neither idealistic nor normative.

- The international system is not anarchic.
- There is only one dominant state at any given time.
- Rather than wishing to maximize security or power, nations are interested in maximizing their **control over the rules and customs that govern international interactions** so that they can define the status quo according to their interests.

Bretton Woods Agreement $\Rightarrow$ These agreements still maintain a rule-based and normative influence on the trading practices of their members.

Dissatisfaction $\Rightarrow$ it is the more powerful dissatisfied states that represent the biggest threat to international peace and stability.

FIGURE 5.5**The Power Transition Power Triangle**

Power transition theory divides the world into two coalitions: (1) satisfied states and (2) dissatisfied states. The stronger a state is, the more likely that it is satisfied with the organization of the international system and the status quo that reflects that system's rules. Weaker states are more likely to be dissatisfied.

Source: Organski (1958).

Figura 1

3.1 Dissatisfaction, the Status Quo, and War

Conflict arises when a dissatisfied state grows strong enough to challenge the authority of the hegemon. Because such a challenge concerns the very way in which international affairs are conducted, the ensuing conflict is fierce and costly.

This time period during which the challenger roughly comes to equal and then surpass the dominant state in power is known as the power transition. It is the time when the threat of a major war is hypothesized to be at its peak. **Contrary to the balance-of-power perspective**, power transition and hegemonic stability theorists believe that major wars are most likely to occur when the power of the opposed states is about equal.

According to these theorists, a balance of power promotes war. They maintain that system-transforming wars—that is, wars that lead to a new power hierarchy and to new rules and norms—will occur only when the power of a challenger and the dominant state are about equal and the power of the challenger is increasing faster than that of the dominant state. These claims have been extended and shown to have **empirical strength** at the regional as well as the global level, so that regional hegemons apparently face the same pressures and the same sources of war as their global counterparts.

Threatening balance of power emerges as a result of differing rates of internal growth between a dominant state and a challenger state. These theories still give little attention to domestic politics per se, but they do recognize that internal factors shape rates of growth.

Power transition theory leads to the hypothesis that system-transforming, high-cost wars are

especially likely when a dissatisfied challenger state achieves approximate power parity with the dominant, status quo-defending state.

Kim and Morrow have shown that the distribution of power at which the rivals will fight depends on their willingness to take the risks of waiting. The longer the challenger waits to attack, the higher is its probability of victory. This is true because the challenger's power is growing faster than the dominant state's power. Thus, the longer the challenger puts off a war, the greater will be the odds in its favor. However, the longer it waits, the longer it must endure the rules of international intercourse with which it is dissatisfied.

Kim and Morrow have shown that the interval during which the challenger is willing to fight expands as the expected costs of the war increase, as the challenger's dissatisfaction with the status quo increases, as the challenger's relative growth rate declines, and as the challenger becomes more risk acceptant.

How long the challenger and the dominant states will wait before fighting depends on their respective responses to risk, their relative rates of growth, the expected costs of the war, and their respective degrees of satisfaction with the status quo.

Differences in growth rates turn out not to be crucial empirically.

Power transitions per se cannot explain especially costly wars.

FIGURE 5.6

Power Transition Theory and the Likelihood of War

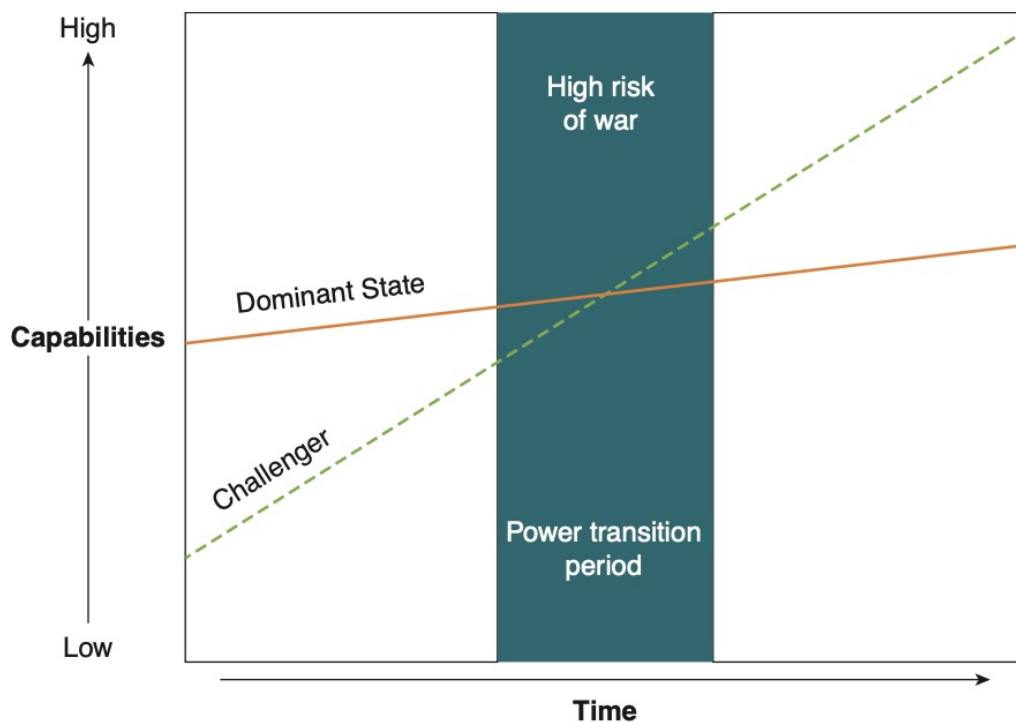


Figura 2

4 Levy, n.d.

This makes it hard to argue that human nature and related factors are causes of war. The point is that these factors are constants and cannot explain the variations in war and peace over time and space (Waltz 1959, Cashman 1993).

Why does war occur at some times rather than other times, between some states rather than other states, under some political leaders rather than others, in some historical and cultural contexts rather than others, and so on? This differs from still a third question: How do we explain the origins of a particular war? Most international relations scholars (and particularly those in North America) focus primarily on the second question, explaining variations in war and peace. They leave the question of why war occurs at all to philosophers and biologists and leave the question of why a particular war occurs to historians.

Although **anarchy** may provide one persuasive answer to the question of the permissive causes of war, it is generally treated as a structural constant and consequently it cannot account for variations in war and peace.

4.1 The Levels-of-Analysis Framework

Waltz (1959) classified the causes of war in terms of their origins in the individual, the nation-state, and the international system $\Rightarrow$ levels-of-analysis framework as an organizing device for the study of war.

In this sense the systemic level of analysis refers to explanations of patterns and outcomes in the international system; the dyadic level refers to explanations of the strategic interactions between two states; the national level refers to explanations of state foreign policy behavior; the organizational level refers to explanations of the behavior of organizations; and the individual level refers to explanations of the preferences, beliefs, or choices of individuals.

We cannot assume that correlations or causal connections at one level of analysis are necessarily valid at another level. It is conceivable, for example, that concentrations of power may promote peace at the dyadic level but war at the system level.

4.2 Systemic-Level Theories

The realist tradition has dominated the study of war since Thucydides and includes Machiavellians, Hobbesians, classical balance of power theorists, Waltzian neorealists, and hegemonic transition theorists. Although different realist theories often generate conflicting predictions, they share a core of common assumptions: the key actors in world politics are sovereign states that act rationally to advance their security, power, and wealth in a conflictual international system that lacks a legitimate governmental authority to regulate conflicts or enforce agreements.

- they use Prisoner's Dilemma and stag-hunt models
- The core proposition of realist theory is that the distribution of power, throughout the system or within a dyad, is the primary factor shaping international outcomes.

We should treat realism as a paradigm rather than as a theory, and focus instead on specific theories that generate more determinant, testable propositions.

4.2.1 Hegemonic Theory or Power Transition Theory

Hegemonic theory is a structural theory that incorporates power transition theory and hegemonic stability theory and that **downplays the importance of anarchy**.

Hegemons commonly arise and use their strength to create a set of political and economic structures and norms of behavior that enhance the stability of the system while advancing their own security. Differential rates of growth, the costs of imperial overextension, and the development of vested domestic interests lead to the rise and fall of hegemons, and the probability of a major war is greatest at the point when the declining leader is being overtaken by the rising challenger.

Power transition theorists disagree somewhat on the precise identity of hegemonic wars and the particular causal dynamics from which they arise.

4.2.2 Balance of Power Theory

Balance of power theory is more concerned with explaining national strategies, the formation of blocking coalitions, the avoidance of hegemony, and the stability of the system than the origins of wars, which are underdetermined.

There is a major debate, however, between classical realists, who argue that stability is further supported by the presence of a multipolar distribution of power and a “flexible” alliance system (Morgenthau 1967, Gulick 1955), and neorealists, who argue that bipolarity is more stable than multipolarity (Waltz 1979, Mearsheimer 1990).

Balance of power theory and power transition theory appear to be diametrically opposed; the former argues that hegemony never occurs and that concentrations of power are destabilizing, and the latter argues the opposite.

4.2.3 Realism and Liberalism

The relationship between economic interdependence and war is an old question that has attracted new attention in the past few years.

Liberal economic theory of war: Montesquieu [1777 (1748)] stated that “peace is the natural effect of trade,” and liberal economic theorists since Smith [1937 (1776)] and Ricardo [1777 (1817)] have argued that capitalist economic systems and the free exchange of goods in an international market economy are the best guarantors of peace.

Realist: they often argue that the effect of trade on war is small relative to that of military and diplomatic considerations. They also question the liberal assumption that trade is always more efficient than military coercion in expanding markets and investment opportunities and in promoting state wealth.

Whether the incentives for the gains from trade dominate the incentives for coercion or protection based on economic asymmetries, and whether the latter escalate to trade wars and militarized conflicts, are empirical questions that analysts have only recently begun to analyze systematically.

Historical and empirical evidence of trade between enemies

Although liberals and realists disagree on the effects of trade on war, **they appear to agree that trade and other forms of economic interchange between societies will cease or be drastically reduced once states are at war with each other**. Contrary to both liberal and realist expectations, however, **there are numerous historical cases of trade between enemies** during wartime, and a preliminary quantitative study suggests that war frequently

does little to depress the volume of trade between adversaries (Barbieri & Levy 1997).

Need to incorporate domestic variables into their hypotheses

States often hesitate to terminate trade with the enemy for fear that they will lose that trade to a third party, who may be a greater economic or military rival.

These omissions have led all but the most committed neorealists to conclude that **systemic-level theories are theoretically incomplete and empirically inadequate**, in that **they leave too much of the variation in the outbreak and expansion of war unexplained**.

4.3 Social-Level Theories

4.4 Individual-Level Theories

decision-making is characterized by “bounded rationality” **Assumptions:**

- (a) that external and internal structures and social forces are not translated directly into foreign policy choices;
- (b) that key decision-makers vary in their definitions of state interests, assessments of threats to those interests, and/or beliefs as to the optimum strategies to achieve those interests; and
- (c) that differences in the content of actors’ belief systems, in the psychological processes through which they acquire information and make judgments and decisions, and in their personalities and emotional states are important intervening variables in explaining observed variation in state behaviors with respect to issues of war and peace.

Prospect Theory one of the most recent attempts to apply a social-psychological model to international relations (Kahneman & Tversky (1979)).

Prospect theory assumes that people evaluate outcomes in terms of deviations from a reference point or aspiration level rather than in terms of net-asset levels.

This asymmetry of behavior with respect to gains and losses means that the way people frame their reference point in any given choice problem is critical.

4.5 General Trends

- shift away from the systemic level: dissatisfaction with the failure of structural systemic models to explain enough of the variance in war and peace. This shift has led to rising interest in both dyadic-level behavior and societal-level explanatory variables.
- Whatever the relationship between concentrations of military and economic capabilities at the systemic level, there is substantial evidence that at the dyadic level an equality of capabilities is significantly more likely to lead to war.
- In the past decade most international relations theorists have moved beyond their earlier preoccupation with explanations at a single level of analysis and debates about which level provides the most powerful explanations. They now give much more attention to interaction effects among variables at different levels in the processes leading to war

Session 3, February 23: The strategic perspective

*** Bueno de Mesquita (2013)[Introduction]

- Bueno de Mesquita (2013)[Chapter 1]
- Bueno de Mesquita (2013)[Chapter 2]

5 Bueno de Mesquita, 2013 Introduction

5.0.1 Basic Principles

1. The actions that leaders take to influence events in the international arena are motivated by their personal welfare and, especially, by a desire to stay in office. Leaders' concerns for the national interest are subordinate to personal interests. If the two coincide, then so much the better; if they do not, leaders do what they believe is best for themselves even when doing so harms most citizens and, in that sense, the national interest.
2. International relations cannot be separated from domestic politics. Every foreign policy action is undertaken in the shadow of the domestic political consequences the action is expected to produce. Therefore, if a foreign policy is expected to achieve beneficial consequences for a nation in the long term but in the short term will result in the ouster of the leader, then that policy will not be pursued.
3. Relations between nations and between leaders are driven by strategic considerations. As such, foreign policy decisions are designed to influence international affairs and the leader's well-being. To be effective in this, foreign policies must be chosen with an eye toward the reaction they will create among friends and adversaries. The reaction expected from a policy choice is compared with the reaction anticipated from other policy options. Leaders pick the policy they believe will produce the best outcome for them, knowing that, at the same time, domestic and foreign rivals are choosing policies to enhance their own well-being.

5.0.2 Liberalism

Liberal theories emerged as a counterweight to the neorealist perspective. Unlike realist approaches, liberalism draws attention to the frequent and often long-standing occurrences of international cooperation. Indeed, a desire to explain such cooperation is its first point of departure from neorealism. Furthermore, for liberal theories, structural hierarchy, which implies the presence of an actor that can authoritatively enforce agreements between states (rather than anarchy, a system in which states must be able to help themselves because they cannot count on anyone else), is the central organizing principle of international politics. The presence of a hegemonic state (an overwhelmingly dominant power) helps enforce norms of conduct and maintain regimes. Norms are generally observed patterns of conduct.

5.0.3 Constructivism

Constructivism, is a theoretical perspective that focuses on explaining how certain types of objectives come into being or change. Constructivism began primarily as an attempt to theorize about the formation of identity, that is how we see ourselves.

Constructivism does not view decision makers as primarily strategic. Rather, leaders are thought initially to adopt a course of action for strategic reasons—to obtain legitimacy—but then to become caught up in socially accepted norms of conduct.

Unfortunately, much of the empirical research to evaluate this theory's conjectures is poorly designed to do so.

Thus, their research designs tend to unintentionally contain an antifalsification bias.

Recent efforts to evaluate constructivism in a manner more consistent with the scientific method tend not to find much support for constructivist hypotheses.

Constructivism leads to the expectation that preferences will converge among the members as they adopt shared norms and are subjected to pressures and persuasion. Nevertheless, König and Luetgert report that, "The results refute the claims of constructivists predicting that positions converge and increase the capacity to act due to common norms, rhetoric action or persuasion" (2005, 6).

5.0.4 A BRIEF HISTORY OF INTERNATIONAL RELATIONS THINKING

Wilson's idealism, the dominant approach to international affairs before World War II, painted a rosy picture of states cooperating with one another in promoting peace, democracy, and prosperity.

Today, realist ideas, in their turn, face significant challenges. These challenges reflect: (1) the insufficiency of realist theories to anticipate or explain the peaceful ending of the Cold War and the accompanying implosion of the Soviet Union and the unraveling of its Eastern European empire (Gaddis 1992); (2) the discovery that several of the most important realist propositions suffer from logical inconsistencies (Milner 1998; Powell 1994, 1999); (3) the discovery that key logically consistent realist propositions turn out to be falsified by the record of history; and (4) the growing evidence that the causes of and solutions to international conflict can be better understood, as urged by Russell and Wright, by looking within states (Bueno de Mesquita et al. 2003; Fearon 1994; Smith 1996).

The Treaty of Westphalia emphasized territoriality over personal loyalties as the foundation for international relations. It was primarily in this emphasis on the institutional importance of borders that the treaty broke with the feudal past.

The idea of territoriality has other significant implications. An important one concerns the central role that states play in international affairs. Because each state's territorial borders define a domain within which its rulers have sovereign authority over the use of force (Krasner 1999; Spruyt 1994), international law has come to view all states as legally equivalent entities. This, in turn, is a factor behind the realist concept of the state as a unitary actor. It is why international relations focus on states and not multinational corporations, ethnic groups, or other ways of dividing up the international pie.

His outlook embodies the idea that there should be no separation of powers, that the state's interests and the leader's interests are one and the same. In such a world, treating states as unitary actors (the king) makes perfectly good sense.

Central among these differences are the extent to which leaders are accountable to a small inner circle of supporters or to a broad constituency and the extent to which leaders insulate themselves from accountability to their core constituency.

Iraq and the Realist View At least in the years 2003-2007, American leaders who were concerned about advancing Iraq's reconstruction seem to have believed, in solid realist fashion, that American power was, by itself, enough to ensure that Iraq would follow the policy path prescribed by the United States.

Iraq's leaders would pay more attention to managing their relations with contending Iraqi factions such as those led by Muqtada al-Sadr (the anti-American cleric) and Grand Ayatollah Ali Sistani

(the more moderate religious leader) than to implementing the policies promoted by the United States. Realist theory leaves little room for such a focus on domestic threats to political survival.

many foreign policy developments, from the collapse of the Soviet Union and the end of the cold war to the morass in Iraq, are at least as much the product of domestic politics as of international competition. To fix such problems, we have to think about the motivations and incentives of leaders and of rival politicians and about how we can alter their behavior based on responding to their motivations and incentives rather than worrying so much about the balance of power between states.

SOLVING INTERNATIONAL RELATIONS PUZZLES Each of these subjects, and many others, are explored in the chapters that follow. These issues are generally discussed in terms of four broad categories of problems: coordination, distribution, monitoring, and sanctioning. Coordination entails finding ways for states or leaders to act together in pursuit of common objectives. Distribution concerns the allocation of scarce goods among citizens, leaders, and states. Monitoring involves detecting situations in which one or another leader or state has cheated on an agreement. Sanctioning concerns punishing cases of cheating. These four generic issues are at the core of cooperation.

5.0.5 Power, Preferences, and Perceptions: The Three Pillars of International Relations

International relations as a subject is primarily about the choices and actions that political leaders take in the name of their nation to influence how their state relates to other states.

In August 1991, for instance, hundreds of thousands of Russian citizens intent on deflating a coup in progress gathered in Moscow's Red Square. Those who gathered there believed that they could help shape the course of events. They acted on this perception by mobilizing the power they had in numbers to display their preference.

Power: Ultimately, power is about mobilizing resources to alter the behavior of others. Power is an instrument for promoting and achieving goals.

Preferences: Foreign policy goals and the ways nations interact with one another are reflections of the preferences, or desires, of key foreign policy leaders and those constituents whose support they require to stay in office. The preferences of constituents are important because if a leader's preferences are sufficiently inconsistent with the wants and desires of his or her core constituents, then the leader runs the risk of being overthrown. Such a risk emanates from two sources. First, opponents capable of jeopardizing a leader's authority may arise from within the state, as is true when there is a revolution, coup, or electoral defeat.

In addition, opponents may arise from outside the state.

Perceptions: Leaders may misjudge the amount of resources or degree of power they can mobilize on behalf of their nation or miscalculate the level of political support that will follow from their pursuit of articulated preferences.

6 Bueno de Mesquita, 2013 Chapter 1, Evaluating Arguments about International Politics

Theories are important in helping us sort out which facts are essential in understanding international affairs.

Every theory should be susceptible to being falsified by evidence and should be evaluated in

terms of its logical consistency.

In keeping with the first principle of wing walking, a theory should not be abandoned before there is substantial evidence in favor of an alternative explanation.

You might think that a review of the history of lots of past events and circumstances is the road to understanding.

Explanations, however, are not strings of facts. Explanation requires theory.

6.1 Constructing Theories

constructing theories $\Rightarrow$ assumptions

1. Assumptions are the principal means by which theorists simplify reality.
2. Assumptions limit the domain of circumstances that the theory is capable of addressing
3. A good starting place to judge a theory's value is to evaluate whether its assumptions contradict one another—that is, whether there are internal inconsistencies.

Judging Theories: Perhaps the most influential international relations theorist of the post-World War II decades, Hans Morgenthau.

Truth and Falsity in Assumptions: So while true and false refer to internal consistency,, useful or trivial refers to its empirical value.

The value of one or another assumption is a practical matter; if an assumption adds to the theory's predictive ability more than it takes away, then it is useful.

The First Principle of Wing Walking If you are out on the wing of an airplane in flight, don't let go of what you are holding on to unless you have something better to hold on to.

The Case Study Method and Testing Theories When cases are selected because they are consistent with a particular claim, they are not a fair test of the accuracy of the claim.

Selection Bias: selection of cases was driven by ex post knowledge of the value on the dependent variable.

The principle of random case selection has been well established among statisticians for over a century.

Remember that theories are about relationships among variables, not about constants.

Example: Commonly, the researcher selects a case with a known cooperative outcome and then looks for the existence of an international regime or organization that can be said to have fostered the cooperative outcome. Perhaps the author is correct in the assessment of the role of the regime, but this does not at all tell us whether similar regimes also operated in settings that did not lead to cooperation between states.

A Standard for Comparing Theories This means we choose one theory over another if it clearly outperforms the competing theory (Popper 1963; Laudan 1977; Lakatos 1978).

The Scientific Method

1. Scientific analysis requires logical consistency
2. Competing arguments can be evaluated through experiments that control for confounding, alternative explanations.

-
3. Randomness ensures that the tests control for the possible effects of other factors.
 4. Tests must also be replicable;

When a Theory Is Wrong A theory is more or less parsimonious depending on how many facts it explains compared with the number of assumptions it requires to make predictions. In general, the more events or facts a theory can explain with a limited set of assumptions, the greater the potential usefulness of the theory and the greater its parsimony.

Scientific Theories Must Be Falsifiable It is essential that a theory seeking the imprimatur of science be susceptible to possible falsification.

Practical use of Theories

7 Bueno de Mesquita, 2013 Chapter 2, The Strategic Perspective

The strategic perspective $\Rightarrow$ 1- foreign policy is part of normal domestic politics 2- any national leader faces a difficult problem in balancing the interests of constituents and the desires of foreign rivals.

Four basic categories of international problems arise: (1) coordination, (2) distribution, (3) monitoring, and (4) sanctioning. Each of these is molded internally by agency problems.

Rather than speaking of governments in categorical terms such as democracy, monarchy, and autocracy, we use two crucial domestic factors to differentiate them: (1) the size of the selectorate (those with a say in choosing leaders) and (2) the size of the winning coalition (those in the selectorate whose support is essential to keep a leader in office).

Polities that rely on a large winning coalition emphasize producing public goods over private rewards for coalition members. They produce greater prosperity, more efficient governance, and low rates of corruption; their leaders stay in office for a relatively short time.

Polities that rely on a small winning coalition and a large selectorate, such as autocracies with rigged elections, tend to produce high degrees of kleptocracy, poor public policies, and high levels of corruption and rent-seeking; their leaders last in office for a very long time.

States with large-winning-coalition systems are more likely to enjoy not only prosperity but also peace, especially with one another, while states with small-winning-coalition systems tend not only to be poor but also to experience lots of wars with other states, as well as undergoing revolutions, civil wars, and coups d'état.

States with large-winning-coalition systems differ from states with small-winning-coalition regimes in their use of foreign aid, military intervention, warfare, and a host of other critical choices in international affairs.

7.1 International Politics: Domestic Politics with a Twist

There is at least one critical difference between domestic and international politics. In the arena of purely domestic affairs, political leaders need not worry that their actions will prompt a foreign government to jeopardize their hold on power.

In domestic politics leaders select policies (including foreign policies) and actions designed to keep them in office.

In international affairs, leaders must worry that their foreign policies not only may mobilize domestic opposition capable of overthrowing them but also may irritate a foreign rival, sparking

attack and possible defeat. That distinction is central to the principles of international politics (Putnam 1988).

7.1.1 Example: The Afghan Taliban's Problem in 2001

Afghanistan's Taliban leaders drew important support from Osama bin Laden and others in Al Qaeda's terrorist network, and Al Qaeda had turned Afghanistan into their home base. For the Taliban to break with them would surely have aroused an active effort by Al Qaeda and its allies to depose the Afghan rulers and replace them with others more likely to cooperate. Yet the United States and its key allies were visibly banding together after September 11, 2001, threatening to overthrow the Taliban government unless it broke with bin Laden. The Taliban chose to gamble that the American threat was less dangerous than the risks associated with breaking with Al Qaeda.

7.1.2 Example: The Israeli Prime Minister's Problem

Without pro-settler policies, it is difficult for any Israeli prime minister to stay in office.

Given that Israel's proportional representation electoral system encourages small, fringe parties and given that the conservative Likud Party and the more centrist Kadima Party both rely on support from religious parties to muster a majority in the Knesset, we know that these parties cannot hold office if they alienate the pro-settlement religious party voters.

Almost certainly all parties to the dispute want a peaceful settlement more than they want war but they cannot agree on the contents of such a settlement (Fearon 1995).

7.1.3 WHO AND WHAT TO STUDY IN INTERNATIONAL AFFAIRS

1- Coordination entails finding ways for states or leaders to act together in pursuit of common objectives. Neither the Israelis nor the Palestinians want to collide; they would all like to coordinate on peace.

2- Distribution concerns the allocation of scarce goods among citizens, leaders, and states.

3- Monitoring involves putting into place the means to detect whether one or another leader or state has cheated on an agreement.

4- Sanctioning concerns punishing cases of cheating and is always susceptible to the parties deciding to renegotiate their agreement because punishing the cheater can be costly for the compliant signatory or signatories too.

International treaties provide a common means of addressing these problems and represent an important feature of international efforts at cooperation.

principal agent problem between the leaders who negotiate and the constituents.

We often don't have enough information to sort out whether our leaders are faithfully serving our interest.

Associated with the principal-agent problem, we as citizens may face another generic problem tied to monitoring and sanctioning our leaders (Aggiungo io, selection problems nel scegliere i leaders).

7.1.4 The Strategic Perspective

Lots of evidence has been compiled that shows international law and international organizations tend to be pretty ineffective when the stakes are high and national leaders are disinclined to abide by common norms of action.

7.1.5 Domestic Theories of International Affairs: A First Look

The actions of leaders are incentive compatible with their desire to stay in power and control revenue allocation.

James Fearon (1994), Alastair Smith (1998), and others suggest that democratic leaders are more likely than autocrats to carry out the foreign policy threats they make because of their domestic political **audience costs**.

Schultz (1998, 2001) shows another feature that follows from having a domestic audience and thus audience costs: because of the risk of losing office following an unsuccessful foreign policy adventure, there is a **selection effect**.

→ **audience costs** ⇒ **selection effect**.

Democratic leaders, facing a legitimate and vocal opposition, are less likely to select risky foreign policies than are autocrats.

Democrats are much more likely to win the wars they start than are autocrats, not just because they are generally better at fighting wars but because they cannot afford to lose if they hope to get reelected.

Domestic Theories of International Affairs: Example Schultz's reasoning offers a compelling explanation for the appearance, and disappearance, of a bipartisan American foreign policy.

Typically, American foreign policy is thought of as nonpartisan and as driven by efforts to advance the national interest. Rarely, however, is there much effort to explain why partisanship should not be as important in foreign policy decisions as it is in the routine domestic choices of political leaders.

If the incumbent party and its leaders select a foreign policy that is unpopular or that is believed will be unsuccessful, then they can anticipate that the other party's leaders and candidates will see an opportunity to win votes by opposing the majority party's foreign policy.

7.2 SELECTORATE THEORY

The selectorate theory represents one version of the strategic perspective.

In selectorate theory, leaders build a coalition of supporters among the selectorate. The selectorate (S) consists of those who have at least a nominal say in choosing leaders and are eligible to become members of a winning coalition. The winning coalition (W) is the subset of the selectorate without whose support an incumbent cannot be sustained in office.

Leaders attempt to retain the loyalty of their supporters by giving them more benefits than any domestic political opponent can credibly promise to deliver. Rewards come in two varieties:

- (1) private goods:

Private goods are rewards that benefit only those who get them—that is, members of the leader’s essential coalition of supporters.

Examples might include privileged access to government contracts, exploitation of a black market, or protection against prosecution.

(2) public goods.

Public goods are government policies and programs that all people benefit from whether they are in the leader’s inner circle or not.

Examples of public goods include national defense, free speech and free assembly, public parks, equal protection under the law, and free access to education.

The selectorate theory’s five rules of governance are as follows:

1. Depend on as few key people to keep you in power as possible.
2. Draw that small group of essential coalition members from as large a pool of people as possible.
3. Tax people as much as possible, subject to the constraints that they continue to work and pay taxes rather than take siestas, and that they are not made so miserable that they decide it is worthwhile to risk revolting rather than continue to live with the existing political system.
4. Reward your essential backers just enough so they stick with you rather than shopping around for a new leader who might do more for them.
5. Don’t spend resources on benefiting the general population when those resources are needed to keep the loyalty of the members of your essential coalition.

When domestic institutions constrain a leader to require a broad base of support private rewards are an inefficient way to retain power (de Tocqueville 2000; Lake and Baum 2001; Bueno de Mesquita et al. 2003; Bueno de Mesquita and Smith 2011). Democratic leaders would have to spread these rewards across so many people that each would receive too little for the benefits to influence their loyalty to the incumbent.

When political institutions compel a leader to depend on many supporters so that a bundle of public goods is the reward for retaining the incumbent, **the institutions of governance induce weak loyalty to the incumbent.**

Conversely, when a leader needs backing only from a few people to stay in power, the few are expected to be loyal both because they are well rewarded with private benefits and because they face a high risk of losing those privileges if a challenger topples the incumbent regime.

FIGURE 2.2 Governance Institutions

Governance Dimensions: Nested Selectorate Institutions

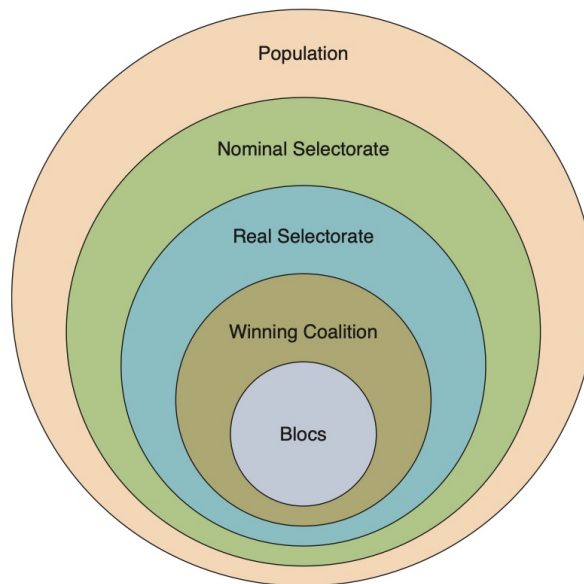


Figura 3

Historically, we have spoken of categorical types of regimes, like democracies or autocracies. In practice, no two governments are alike. All political systems have two institutional characteristics that describe how they retain and select their leaders.

When W/S is small, as in a rigged election autocracy, then there is a **strong loyalty norm** that makes it easy for leaders to survive in power and exert great discretion over revenue as explained next.

Examples: Egypt vs HCina and Syria vs Nigeria For example, China and Egypt both had winning coalitions with a size that was close to 0 percent of the adult population, yet Egypt back then had a larger real selectorate than China relative to their adult populations. This means that both regimes, as we will see, were heavily oriented toward private goods but that leaders had more discretion over revenue in Egypt than in China. All else being equal, then, Egypt's then leader Hosni Mubarak had a better chance of remaining in power against an ordinary political challenge than did China's then incumbent president Hu Jintao.

Syria and Nigeria differ markedly. Nigeria has a smaller selectorate than Syria but depends on a much larger winning coalition. This means that the loyalty norm is stronger in Syria than in Nigeria. That makes the preparedness of the winning coalition's members to take extraordinary actions on behalf of the incumbent regime more robust in Syria than in Nigeria.

Examples: Putin Putin needed support from only half the members of parliament to get their legislative program through the Duma and, in a two-party race, each candidate needed only half the voters to support him to be elected, making the maximum minimal winning coalition in Russia 25 percent [0.5 (voters per seat) $\times$ 0.5 (number of seats)]. With more than two parties (and there were seven parties contesting the 2011 Duma election), the actual minimal winning coalition was smaller.

7.3 Public and Private Goods: Who Gets Rewarded as W and S Change?

W = Winning Coalition, it is the subset of the selectorate without whose support an incumbent cannot be sustained in office.

R = Total revenues

p = price of public goods

g = mix of public goods

z = each coalition member's private goods benefits

$$z = (R - p * g) / W$$

The odds of being in a successor coalition are the ratio W/S , which in this case is 100/1,000,000, or 1/10,000.

The expected value of the prospective defector's share of the private goods to be dispensed by the successor regime is only 1000.

$$\frac{\text{total revenues}}{\text{number of winning coalition}} * \text{probability of belonging to the coalition} =$$

$$\frac{R}{W} * \frac{W}{S} = \frac{1,000,000,000}{100} * \frac{100}{1,000,000} = 1000$$

The incumbent can keep the difference between the 10 million per supporter that could be distributed, and the something above 1,000 per supporter that needs to be distributed.

It is easy to see that as long as the incumbent beats that expectation and provides public policies that are not much worse than those proposed by the challenger, the would-be defector can be kept happy and loyal.

7.3.1 Conclusions

1. **the greatest incumbency advantage in using private goods to satisfy constituents belongs to the leaders of political systems that have small winning coalitions and large selectorates.**
2. **Supporters in a large-coalition public-goods-oriented setting receive the benefits of public goods even if their leader is replaced by a challenger, such as after an election. This means that they can support a challenger with little consequence since they are getting few private gains in any event.**

7.3.2 Leader Survival

Autocracy and democracy are fundamentally different in their consequences even though all leaders are assumed to want the same thing (to keep their jobs and have discretion over as many resources as possible). Democratic politics in selectorate theory is a competition in competence to produce public goods; autocratic politics centers on the purchase of the loyalty of key supporters through bribery, corruption, and rent seeking.

7.3.3 Conclusion

The selectorate theory logically implies several basic principles of politics that are applied repeatedly throughout this book. The most important of these principles are as follows:

1. Regimes with large winning coalitions focus on effective policies, including foreign policies. When leaders' policies do poorly, they either switch them or pour more resources into trying to make them succeed.
2. Regimes with small winning coalitions tolerate failed domestic and foreign policies better than do regimes with large coalitions because in small-coalition settings loyalty to a leader depends more on receiving private rewards than public benefits. As a consequence, leaders mostly continue on their policy course even when their policies are failing. They do not change course as quickly as large-coalition leaders, and they do not put extra resources into trying to make the policies, including foreign security and trade policies, succeed under most circumstances.
3. The likelihood that a leader survives in office despite failed policies increases as W/S decreases (so that the polity becomes more autocratic) and decreases as W/S increases (so that the polity becomes more democratic).
4. As W/S increases, leaders must spend more revenue to maintain loyalty among their coalition members and, as a result, these leaders have proportionately fewer revenue sources at their discretionary use than do those who depend on a small coalition drawn from a large selectorate.
5. Corruption and kleptocracy (governing by theft) increase in prominence as W gets smaller, especially when S also gets larger.
6. The foreign policies of small-coalition leaders are more heavily driven by the pursuit of opportunities for enrichment through territorial conquest, tribute, and the like rather than the pursuit of policy compliance from foreign rivals.
7. The foreign policies of large-coalition leaders are more heavily driven by the pursuit of policy compliance by foreign governments than by the pursuit of enrichment.
8. When leaders can change political arrangements, they prefer to decrease the size of their coalition and increase the size of the selectorate.
9. When coalition members can change institutions (e.g., through coups), they always prefer to increase the ratio W/S and may, depending on circumstances, prefer to do so by increasing W more quickly than S or decreasing W more slowly than S .
10. When people who are not in the coalition have the opportunity to change institutions of government (e.g., through revolution or civil war), they always prefer to increase W and to increase W/S .

Bibliography

Books

Bueno de Mesquita, B. (2013). *Principles of International Politics*. CQ Press. <http://ebookcentral.proquest.com/lib/unimannheim-ebooks/detail.action?docID=1994623>

Articles

Lake, D. A. (2011). Why “isms” Are Evil: Theory, Epistemology, and Academic Sects as Impediments to Understanding and Progress1: Why “isms” are Evil. *International Studies Quarterly*, 55(2), 465–480. <https://doi.org/10.1111/j.1468-2478.2011.00661.x>

Lake, D. A., Martin, L. L., & Risse, T. (2021). Challenges to the Liberal Order: Reflections on *International Organization*. *International Organization*, 75(2), 225–257. <https://doi.org/10.1017/S0020818320000636>

Levy, J. S. (n.d.). The Causes of War and the Conditions of Peace.

Milner, H. V., Powers, R., & Voeten, E. (2023). The Myth of the Eclectic IR Scholar? *International Studies Perspectives*, 24(3), 308–335. <https://doi.org/10.1093/isp/ekac012>

One World, Rival Theories. (n.d.).